

All Roads Lead to Now

Abstract

I first read this book in early September 2024 and posted a review on Goodreads around that time. A condensed and edited version of that review was published in *Beyond the Last Estate* no. 2 (Fall 2024). In 2026, I decided to complete the piece.

The chill sank past skin to bone and the downpour did not break. Hours remained but the afternoon darkened just the same, still early in September. My knees moved up and down out on the country lane, turned the bike pedals. My feet were attached to the pedals with straps, and the pedals turned a chain that looped around a fixed cog such that I could not stop my body from moving without applying muscular force to brake the vehicle. I don't remember how long it had been like that, but with the voice not having yet abated, I found myself in the country west of Granby.

A stand of picnic benches approached on the left. The canopy provided insubstantial shelter from the rain. Within thirty seconds of pacing back and forth, a cloud of mosquitoes had gathered around me. I pushed off again.

On either side of the path rose a steep grade covered in thick growth. A shape rose out of the mist above the trees ahead. The iron skeleton of a half-built structure. It rose in right angles above the trees. They were building something new. A siding broke on my right. I stood my weight on the pedals, slowed enough to turn and leave the path.

The road led to a manufacturing zone, a dark grey plane, wet, flat, and striated with narrow green lawns and lifeless sheds, big as airplane hangars in their concrete lots. I made my way down the road, dismounted to lift my bike over a loose chain strung up to keep out trespassers. No mosquitoes here, no vegetation of any kind. They had put a roof up but not yet the walls, a field of crushed stone, a foundation ready to pour the concrete. Rain battered the thin metal roof.

I made camp with my back against a lime-green forklift. Stakes were useless in the hard ground so I dragged over buckets weighed down with rubberized bolts, tied off my guylines and stretched

As darkness and mist obscured the night, I kept a sharp ear tuned, constantly imagining a hulking predator with a metal pyramid for a head.

Figure 1: As darkness and mist obscured the night, I kept a sharp ear tuned, constantly imagining a hulking predator with a metal pyramid for a head.

the tent fabric taut. After unrolling my bedding and fastening on my headlamp, I unwrapped the book from its plastic.

The blue book, with the title *Flights* printed in white across the cover, contains the following text:

What the Shrouded Runaway was Saying

So go, sway, walk, run, take flight, because the second you forget and stand still his massive hands will seize you and turn you into just a puppet, you'll be enveloped in his breath, stinking of smoke and fumes and the big rubbish dumps outside town...For anything that has a stable place in this world—every country, church, every human government, everything that has preserved a form in this hell—is at his command. Everything that is defined, that spans from here to there, that fits into a framework, is written down in registers, numbered, testified to, sworn to; everything collected, displayed, labelled. Everything that holds: houses, chairs, beds, families, earth, sowing, planting, verifying growth. Planning, awaiting the results, outlining schedules, protecting order...Whoever pauses will be petrified, whoever stops, pinned like an insect, his heart pierced by a wooden needle, his hands and feet drilled through and pinned into the threshold and the ceiling...What they want is to pin down the world with the aid of barcodes, labelling all things, letting it be known that everything is a commodity, that this is how much it will cost you. Let this new foreign language be illegible to humans, let it be read exclusively by automatons, machines. That way by night, in their great underground shops, they can organize readings of their own barcoded poetry.

Move. Get going. Blessed is he who leaves. *Flights*, 266-268

Judging books by their covers. Maybe it's not just me and the voice alone together after all. Maybe one day the voice will be heard. The voice that says it's mine, which I have transcribed

here in words and placed in wait, waiting for you to come along, to pick it up so that the voice can speak and be heard and come alive again.

Fitzcarraldo Editions decided to print all their books with a blue cover, Yves Klein blue (#002FA7), the title in white and otherwise unadorned. With my damp fingers I can't fail to notice the paper's pleasing hand. Its voice sounds blue, like a thought that has made itself objective reality. The same sound a skyscraper makes, or a voting booth. Short stories and novels are forms of objective reality. All of these are different kinds of creatures than the voice that speaks. That is a voice like mine. Another body, alive, or dead, it doesn't matter. A book means little. The voice means little other than that it speaks. To be heard is a privilege. It means little. My larynx vibrates, my tongue twists, a voice echoes in my eardrum. Why listen when we can speak? Why go to all the lengths of recognizing another when we can drown it all out? The voice waits, it has nowhere to go. It will speak to you if you let it. Maybe if the voice changes how it speaks, you'll be more likely to listen. If I can just find the right pitch, my works will speak and live the life I thought I wanted for myself.

If it sticks to short speeches, you can take it like a daily pill, trick yourself into thinking, moving, circulating blood to the limbs until you believe that you could stand up and be heard. To only need to read a page or two, here and there, takes less time from the pleasure of not thinking than it does to listen to the breathless voices of single-sentence books like *Zone* (Mathias Énard, Fitzcarraldo Editions, 2014), or Zakir Jamal's "Higher Things."

Voices have always made short books of themselves, alternately called short stories, or essays. Not quite as old a form as the novel, but old enough for us to know they are mostly beloved by professionals, those who look to make themselves a part of objective reality—or by other spirits with a taste for being heard. At least there are those who collect books, like piles of dead leaves, and who perhaps if drawn by the right shade of blue might stop and listen.

Flights is a book whose voice has been thinking about how a novel can sound like **Contemporary life**. A life spent like they always have been, which is to say wasted in the struggle for existence. What's new is the addition of a *Noz* that never ends, an unfulfilled cusp, no ground beneath your feet. I bend my knee under the sheets until it pops. *Flights* shows us how a book can mimic objective reality, but still constitute the thought of a free spirit. It resembles a novel, and manages to uncover new ways that the novel speaks of its time. Every voice that manages

to speak in a manner appropriate to its thought, to unite form and content, is automatically *sui generis*. Every novel is about the voice that speaks it, and every voice that speaks its truth will always be particular because no two truths are alike. It escapes capture by the institution. *Flights* shows us a new way for the novel.

What's it about? It begins at an airport. She stops to listen to a speech delivered by an unfamiliar kind of missionary. She's Polish, a woman, well-learned, a writer of sufficient renown to be called upon to travel, and a loner, the sort who might be given to inventing imaginary friends¹. The narrator shares all the same features as the author, but information about the author is confined to the meta-text.

The novel is printed in a running column, punctuated every three to seven pages by a new section. It resembles a scroll more than a codex. But it's a book just the same. Each section tells a different story, some based on real personages. Certain characters return, including the narrator, who continues to stop and listen to the missionaries of the new airport cult. This framing device persists while the book moves between first and third person, between story-telling and argumentation. This blurry zone, only semi-fictional, anchored in the first-person, heedless of sentence-level precision, is characteristic of the formless form of Contemporary literature².

This style, undoubtedly of the *Now*, we might also call *post-fictional*. Although Olga Tokarczuk's character in *Flights* is tame and kind—she only listens and has pleasant interactions with the cultists, does not find any frightening sigil painted in her motel mirror—the events that happen to her are obviously invented, and also contain little gossip. This is not just a marked contrast from autofiction, but also shows us how certain techniques are used to frame narrative as true, or “post-fictional.” The first-person perspective of the author, whose actions are narrativized, and who is also presented as identical with the author, all play on the meta-text to increase the work's verisimilitude. The “reality effect” is what makes the work more accessible, by making the work

¹“When writing my latest novel... I asked this advanced [LLM] model what kind of songs my protagonists would be listening to at a dance, a few dozen years ago, and AI gave me a few titles,” Tokarczuk told the interviewer. “Often I just ask the machine, ‘darling, how could we develop this beautifully?’ Even though I know about hallucinations and many factual errors in the algorithms in terms of economics and hard data, I have to add that in literary fiction this technology is an advantage of unbelievable proportion.”

²The critical-rhetorical form is what has the true advantage, the value-add in an age where reading has become a status-marker.

> “I prefer to read good literary criticism. That way I get the ideas of the novel, as well as the critic.” **metropolitan?**, citation needed.

feel less constructed, less over-determined and inaccessible. When a text reveals itself to be merely rhetorical, we have a better sense of how to manage it. It's the works of art that are more likely to hurt us, to frustrate us with their opacity.

Organized around the twin themes of travel and anatomy, two themes which in themselves retain much relevance for how our lives are structured in the post-Fordist, Toyota model of "late capitalism," i.e. neoliberalism ³.

The Shrouded Woman recurs throughout the text, one of a few narratives braided together and returned to. A transient who lives in the Moscow metro, she lays out the politics of our age—as well as those of the novel. Like all good art, the work is wise enough to refrain from taking specific ideological stances. Its politics are implicit, read into the foundations of the work. Like all artefacts of the liberal order, it is invested in disguising its own ideological foundations.

It's dark outside my tent, the rain has slowed, I can hear the sounds of the forest. In the distance, someone is revving the motor on their car, burning donuts on wet concrete. The book's style reminds me of my own writing. There is much more telling than showing, the research is superficial, and the sentences are clunkers. Yet, the tone is also perfectly level, as it needs to be to sustain movement between so many different genres and perspectives. Some of the narratives that come later in the book are more immersive and descriptive and therefore emotionally affecting—and yet throughout, this novel's fictionality has an irregular quality.

Despite the unmediated narrative frame and the short sections timed to the length of a commute, a significant portion of the public still perceive the work as long and inaccessible. It's a thick book, attractively packaged, and an objective success. But the author's own faith has faltered: "people are not interested in long books anymore" [1].

In *Drive Your Plow Over the Bones of the Dead*, the prose style is far more refined, pleasing, and noticeable—but still anchored in an informal first-person perspective. I began to notice the repetition of the phrase "kind of" on nearly every page. Here are a few selections:

"It had its place in the hierarchy of rivers, which I later checked on the maps—a minor one, but present, nonetheless, a **kind of** country viscountess at the court of the Amazon Queen." *Flights*, 8

³citation needed

“Everyone says this over and over like a **kind of** mantra.” *Flights*, 39–40

“From within, from the road, the island seemed small, but now its power is made manifest: solid rock shaped into a **kind of** monumental cone, a fist hurled out of the water.” *Flights*, 46

Imperfections in art have an effect, and many artists who have mastered their media will intentionally create imprecise, imperfect-seeming works to produce a certain effect. The repetition of “kind of,” which one thinks would have been edited out, has a certain effect. The writing sounds unpolished, informal, and therefore accessible, like all autofiction: we identify with the author–narrator, transpose ourselves onto them, take on their perspective, as in cinema ⁴. *Flights* is deliberately and intentionally unpretentious, not particularly smart or complex despite getting into obscure history and covering a range of different concepts and subjects. By the narrator’s own admission, research does not always go deeper than Wikipedia. All the images are taken from a single book.

In *Reality Hunger*, David Shields talks about how the books that feel new and exciting will invite the reader behind the curtains, not just showing them the created object, but inviting them into its process of creation. This is why autofiction is such an important genre. There is an autofictional element to this book, but one which actually stays “professional,” does not revel in the gossip of reality TV. When the “I” emerges, it is associated with Tokarczuk the author, in all her facticity, rather than, for example, the fictional narrator of *Drive Your Plow Over the Bones of the Dead*. This, and the framing perspective within the text, are both accessibility measures accomplished through minimal means.

Read this book in order. Despite all of its breaking-of-form, combining essay and history and fiction in an accessible style, treating themes that are relevant to the particular ways that 21st century capitalism has structured society (the twin themes of travel & anatomy). Contemporary age, the book is adamantly a novel. It is not a diary, not a work of non-fiction, not a work of *creative* non-fiction, and least of all is it a short story collection.

The author’s care is not applied unduly towards polishing her prose; instead, it goes towards

⁴In other words, the spectator *identifies with himself*, with himself as a pure act of perception (as wakefulness, alertness): as the condition of possibility of the perceived and hence as a kind of transcendental subject, which comes before every *there is*. *Identification, Mirror*, 49

selecting the content of each section, arranging them in order such that the book forms an emotional arc, such that each unit reveals a different aspect of the book's central concerns. Again, the most popular review here talks about how she gets certain facts wrong, that the book is not that researched⁵. I read that review before reading the book and was on the look-out for feelings of misgiving, which I never had because I read it as a work of fiction, and therefore did not care about facticity.

It's a Contemporary novel that manages to break the form up, shake it loose and make itself accessible to Contemporary audiences—and at the same time, to keep that tradition alive, to keep the nucleus of the form moving forward.

The next morning, the sky has cleared. I tear down my tent, squish my sleeping bag into its sack, take my dried shirt and socks down and dress myself. I don't know how much longer I have on this path. I fear that my pilgrimage contains to true end; that life is a pilgrimage between two waypoints (birth / death). Some choose to stake their claim and lay down roots. They have something to live for. I have no roots. I have nothing to live for other than myself. I have nothing to write for, other than the voice that says it's mine, and which will not stop speaking

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⁵This claim has greater significance after Tokarczuk's public professing of love for AI.